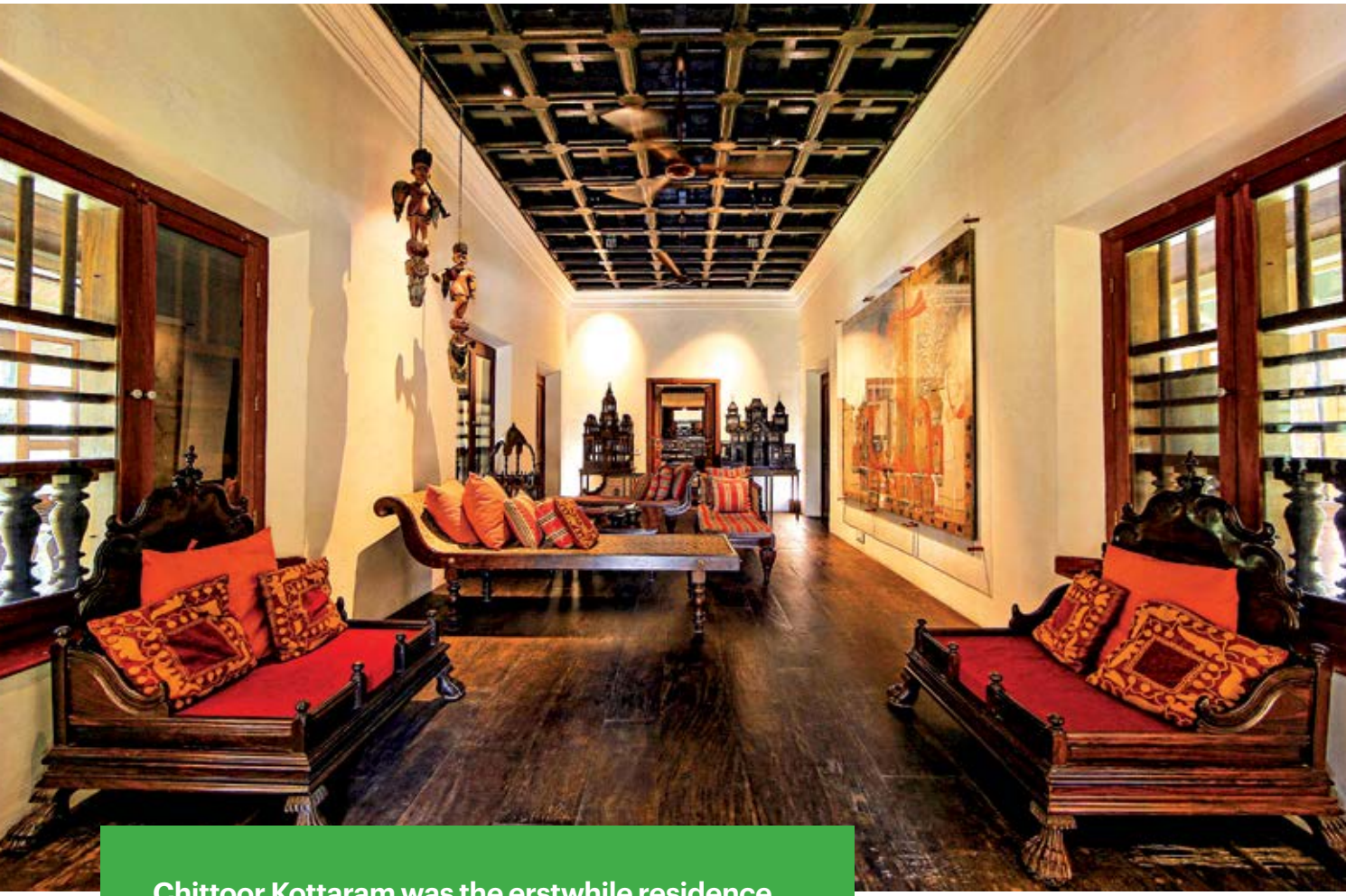


Chittoor Kottaram was the erstwhile residence of the Maharaja of Cochin whenever he visited the Chittoor Krishna Temple. It's been renovated by the Helen Hamlyn Trust with museum-grade antiques and ceiling-to-floor artworks

named Anaikadavu Estate because it was a haunt for pachyderms. Anaimudi, the highest peak in South India, was tagged after its resemblance to an elephant's head.

Chokramudi towered high at 7,200 ft, apparently resembling Lord Shiva's head. While hikes to Chokramudi and Letchmi Hills in Tata Tea's plantation through grassland and shola forests were not suited for the rains because of the slippery trails, there was plenty else to do. Lockhart was the first tea factory built by the British in 1936 and one of the oldest orthodox tea manufacturing facilities in India. Our romantic notions of an English planter called 'Craig Lockhart' were dashed as we learnt that the name was linked to Munnar's cool climes. Craig is Scottish for stone and the place was so cold, it 'locks your heart'. Temperatures in winter can plummet to a frosty –5°C, with only a hot cuppa to revive you. A guided tour of Lockhart Tea Factory revealed how orthodox tea is made, ending in a tea-tasting session.

The tea bushes and adjoining forests are perfect for the nocturnal pastime of 'herping'. No, nothing venereal...it's derived from herpetology and entails searching for amphibians and reptiles. Nearly 40 frog and 30 reptile species have been recorded in Munnar. Guided by Senthil Kumar of Kestrel Adventures, we used torches to scout for frogs on trees and branches! A Beddomes Bush Frog lay perfectly camouflaged on an embankment. The call of the Mewing Night Frog was feline, hence its scientific name *Nyctibatrachus poocha* (*poocha* is Malayalam for cat). The next morning, a slight drizzle stirred the birds into frenzied activity as we spotted the endemic Palani Hills Laughingthrush, Grey-headed Canary Flycatcher, Scimitar Babbler and the rare endemic Dusky Palm Squirrel in the garden.